The Visibility of Coordination: A Gramscian Reading of the Platform Economy and Its Successor

Alessandro Daliana*

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Abstract

Gramsci [1971] observed that the most durable forms of power are those embedded so deeply in common sense that they become invisible: the dominant arrangements rule not only through coercion but by appearing natural, inevitable, and beyond question. This paper applies the concept of cultural hegemony to contemporary coordination infrastructure—the platforms, intermediaries, and standing institutional containers through which most economic exchange between strangers passes today.

We argue that the proposition "two strangers need a platform to transact safely" has achieved hegemonic status in the precise Gramscian sense: it is no longer argued for; it is presupposed in the language used to describe alternatives. The same observation applies to the propositions that production requires firms (the Coasean assumption) and that cross-border trade requires state- or alliance-controlled corridors. Each of these is a contingent design choice that has acquired the appearance of structural necessity.

A recently developed settlement primitive—formalized in the mechanism paper and implemented and verified in the implementation paper—makes the coordination function *visible* by separating it from the entities that currently perform it, and in doing so opens the organizational space to patterns of which the firm is only one. The primitive is not a better firm or a decentralized platform; it is an *organizational substrate* on which multiple coordination forms can be expressed, the way electricity is a substrate on which multiple vehicle architectures can be built. Legacy institutions trying to describe the primitive in firm-vocabulary are doing what internal-combustion manufacturers do when they try to build an electric car by reusing the engine bay. This paper is concerned not with the primitive itself but with what its existence reveals about the incumbent arrangement: how a contingent infrastructure passes for natural gravity, why challenging it is qualitatively different from challenging an explicit ideology, and what kind of communicative work is required to make existing architecture legible as architecture.

The aim is not predictive but diagnostic. We do not argue that the primitive will displace incumbents; we argue that recognizing such displacement as conceivable is itself the political-economy problem.

Keywords: cultural hegemony, Gramsci, platform economy, political economy of infrastructure, coordination substrate, paradigm shift

1 Introduction

This paper sits between political economy and the philosophy of infrastructure. Its starting point is a recently developed settlement primitive that prices the cost of trust at a fixed multiple of transaction value, with no recurring extraction and no arbitrator. The mechanism (asymmetric

*Corresponding author. adaliana@figaro.org

bonding plus buyer dominance with atomic resolution), its verified Solidity implementation, and the institutional-economic implications for the boundary of the firm have been treated in detail in their own registers. The present paper takes those contributions as given and asks a different question.

If the primitive's institutional consequences are as argued—if a class of standing intermediaries becomes structurally unnecessary in a precisely defined region of transaction space—why is the consequence so difficult to communicate? Why does the proposal land, in venues outside its immediate technical audience, as either obvious-but-unimportant or implausible-by-construction? The pattern is consistent enough to warrant explanation. The explanation we offer is Gramscian.

What this paper is and is not. This paper is an essay in the political economy of infrastructure. It does not extend the mechanism, prove new theorems, or make empirical predictions. Its claim is diagnostic: the difficulty of arguing for an alternative coordination architecture is a function of the incumbent architecture's hegemonic status, not of the alternative's intrinsic implausibility. The argument is short because the underlying observation is simple. We hope it is useful to those working on infrastructure design, on platform critique, or on the sociotechnical conditions of legitimate institutional change.

2 Hegemony in the Gramscian Sense

Gramsci [1971] distinguished two registers of class rule: *coercion* (the state's monopoly on violence) and *consent* (the cultural saturation that makes the dominant arrangements appear inevitable). The latter, which he called *egemonia*, operates not by compelling agreement but by constituting the field within which agreement and disagreement become legible. A hegemonic proposition is not believed; it is *presupposed in the question.* To dispute it is not to disagree—it is to fail to make sense.

Gramsci developed the concept in the context of class formation in early-twentieth-century Italy, but the structure generalizes. Any arrangement that is required to be argued for has not yet achieved hegemony; any arrangement whose absence is unimaginable has exceeded it. Between these poles lie the durable institutions whose contingency is recognized in principle but functionally repressed in practice—the institutions that one knows, on reflection, could have been otherwise, but whose otherwise one finds oneself unable to seriously entertain.

Gramsci's own formulation of hegemony [Gramsci, 1971] is the starting point; subsequent scholarship (Anderson 1976, Hall 1986, 1988, Laclau and Mouffe 1985) has debated how its apparatus extends beyond the class-political setting Gramsci originally addressed. The reading we use here draws on three strands of that scholarship in particular. From Gramsci [1971] itself we take the distinction between *war of manoeuvre* (direct confrontation with the dominant configuration) and *war of position* (the slower, more durable work of establishing alternative common sense in the institutions and vocabulary through which the configuration is reproduced); the present argument belongs to the latter register, since the bonded primitive does not displace the platform at the level of operation but in the longer-term register of what coordination looks like. From Gramsci we also take *passive revolution* — the process by which a hegemonic bloc absorbs the vocabulary and some of the demands of a counter-hegemonic challenge while neutralizing its substantive claim — as a recurring caution: the likely path through which the bonded primitive's vocabulary will enter mainstream discourse is via incumbents adopting the words "decentralized," "self-sovereign," "trustless" for products that retain the structural properties the primitive eliminates. The Gramscian distinction we owe the reader is between adoption of vocabulary and substitution of substrate; only the latter is what we describe.

From Hall [1986, 1988] we take hegemony as the saturating work that secures consent to a particular configuration of forces by making that configuration appear natural; Hall's *The Hard*

Road to Renewal is the closer methodological precedent because it analyzes a specific hegemonic project (Thatcherism) as an articulation of common sense rather than as an elite program, and the analytic posture transfers directly to platform/firm/corridor configuration. From Laclau and Mouffe [1985] we take the discursive-formation reading of hegemony as articulation of otherwise-disjoint elements into a coherent ideological configuration: the platform, the firm, and the corridor are articulated together in the dominant discourse not because they share a structural origin but because they have become mutually referring within the language of mainstream economics, business journalism, and policy.

The adjacent theoretical frames we draw on are Polanyi's analysis of the disembedding of markets from the social fabric they presuppose [Polanyi, 1944]; the infrastructure-studies tradition on visibility and invisibility of coordination systems [Bowker and Star, 1999, Star, 1999]; Srnicek [2017]'s typology of platform capitalism into rentier, lean, industrial, product, and advertising platforms (each of which extracts coordination rent through different attributes of the same underlying intermediation function); Zuboff [2019]'s analysis of *instrumentarian power* as a register of control distinct from both classical disciplinary power and from market exchange; and Pasquale [2015]'s analysis of opacity as the operating logic of contemporary algorithmic intermediation. The present paper is a short essay at the intersection of these traditions, not a full engagement with any of them.

Platform hegemony, distinct from generic platform-critique. A natural worry, given the citation density above, is that "platform hegemony" is just generic platform-critique with Gramscian vocabulary attached. The distinction is structural rather than terminological. A non-Gramscian platform-critique typically argues that the platform's rent extraction is *exploitative* and that better regulation, public ownership, or worker cooperatives would deliver the same coordination function on better terms. The Gramscian critique here is that the platform is the form coordination has taken under a particular historical configuration, and that the "coordination function" as currently bundled — search, matching, escrow, dispute resolution, reputation, enforcement — is itself a hegemonic production rather than a list of services that any sufficiently advanced civilization must produce. The bonded primitive lets us see the bundle as a bundle, and disaggregating it is the war-of-position move; rebundling it under different ownership is what passive revolution would look like.

Three hegemonic propositions. We identify three propositions about contemporary coordination infrastructure that meet the Gramscian criterion. Each is contingent in principle; each is presupposed in practice.

1. **Two strangers need a platform to transact safely.** The proposition is so deeply embedded that arguments *against* platform fees are conducted in the platform's own register: smaller fees, fairer fees, regulated fees, public platforms. The proposition that no platform is required typically appears, in mainstream discourse, as either utopian or fraudulent. Yet for centuries, most economic exchange occurred without anything resembling the contemporary platform.

2. **Production requires firms.** Examined in detail elsewhere; here we note only that the proposition is so naturalized that debates about "the future of work" are typically debates about the conditions of employment within firms, not debates about whether the firm is the right unit of production at all.

3. **Cross-border trade requires corridors controlled by state or alliance actors.** Ports, railways, undersea cables, payment rails, settlement networks: the proposition that these must be controlled by some sovereign or coalition is so embedded that the distinction between "geopolitical competition for control" and "geopolitical contestation of necessity" is rarely made.

These are not the only hegemonic propositions about coordination, but they suffice for the argument. Each presents itself as structural; each is, on inspection, contingent on a particular historical configuration of available primitives.

The historical bloc. A Gramscian analysis is incomplete without naming the bloc that sustains the hegemonic arrangement. The three propositions above are sustained, jointly, by the configuration we will call the *industrial-enforcement bloc*: industrial and financial capital that has accumulated within firm-shaped containers; a managerial class whose authority derives from the subordination relation that the firm institutionalizes; platform operators that extract coordination rent at the choke points where firms, consumers, and service providers meet; and state apparatuses whose enforcement capacity and property-rights frameworks make the firm-shaped container the privileged legal subject of contract, credit, and compliance. The propositions do not float free; they are common sense because this configuration has been the coordination substrate for the historical period within which modern economies have formed. A counter-hegemonic formation, in the Gramscian sense, would require not simply an alternative technology but the emergence of organic intellectuals whose vocabulary makes the configuration legible as a configuration rather than as gravity.

Empirical signature of hegemonic crisis. The configuration we describe is not stable. The Edelman [2026] Trust Barometer, conducted annually since 2001, has tracked steady cross-national decline in public trust of the institutions whose authority sustains the platform/firm/corridor arrangement: business, government, media, and NGOs. The decline is not bounded to any country or sector; it is structural. Sophisticated institutions can carry sophisticated capture, and the present-moment data are consistent with a hegemonic apparatus losing the saturating presupposition it requires. This does not by itself produce a counter-hegemonic formation — a war of position requires more — but it locates the moment in the Gramscian sequence: when the configuration can no longer rely on common sense, articulating its contingency becomes legible in ways it was not before.

Hegemonic convergence and Schelling convergence are different. A distinction worth drawing: the hegemonic convergence we have been describing is *presupposed* convergence — the arrangement is common sense because participants do not deliberate about it. *Schelling convergence*, in the sense of Schelling [1960], is *recognized* convergence — participants knowingly pick a focal point because they correctly expect others to pick it, and the recognition is part of the coordination mechanism. The contemporary platform/firm/corridor configuration operates in the first register; the FIGARO-aligned cohort operating around the bonded primitive and its native token (cf. the FIG token paper) operates in the second. This distinction sharpens the visibility argument of Section 3: counter-hegemonic coordination is necessarily a Schelling process because a counter-hegemonic arrangement cannot be presupposed while it is still being argued for. The work of making a coordination arrangement legible is, in part, the work of establishing it as a credible Schelling point around which aligned participants can converge without central authority.

3 The Coordination Function as Design Choice

The reading we propose is that the settlement primitive of the mechanism paper makes the coordination function visible by separating it from the entities that currently perform it. We offer this as an interpretive claim of the present paper, not as a theorem of the mechanism paper: Paper A establishes equilibrium properties of a bonding game composed of two mechanisms — asymmetric bonding (which prices enforcement) and buyer dominance with atomic resolution (which propagates coordination through the bonded mesh) — and the separation reading is the political-economy lens through which we propose those properties be understood. Under that lens, the platform's coordination function (matching, enforcement, dispute resolution) becomes a public smart contract. The firm's coordination function (search, negotiation, enforcement) becomes three reducible costs. The corridor's coordination function (settlement, standards, access control) becomes a bilateral mechanism. Crucially, the *multi-party coordination* function of these legacy entities — the work of holding N parties in synchronized commitment through to a single resolution — becomes the work of Mechanism 2 rather than of an organizational nucleus.

The crucial move is not replacement but separation. In each case, the entity does not need to be *replaced*; it needs to be *seen.* Once the coordination function is identified as a specific bundle of services that some technology provides—rather than as an undifferentiated property of the entity that currently provides it—the bundle becomes disaggregable. Disaggregation, in turn, makes substitution conceivable.

3.1 Figaro as Organizational Substrate

The reframing we propose is that the bonded settlement primitive is not a better firm, a better platform, or a better corridor. It is a *substrate*: an infrastructural layer on which multiple organizational forms can be expressed, only one of which is the firm. Holacracy, to pick one recent example, was a network-native coordination experiment confined to a single firm's ownership nucleus; the primitive generalizes network-native coordination *beyond* any particular nucleus, and in doing so opens the organizational space to patterns that the firm paradigm has no vocabulary for — standing treasury communities, transaction-scoped assemblies, agent coalitions, peer networks that cross institutional and jurisdictional lines. We take "substrate" here as a working hypothesis of the present paper; the formal question of which composed mechanisms preserve the kernel's bonding equilibrium (the conditions under which substrate-building is defensible) is the subject of the *coordinator pattern*, which we treat as the supporting technical artifact.

The appropriate analogy is not between software tools but between energy substrates. The transition from coal to oil and gas produced a new industrial landscape; the internal-combustion engine was one of its emblematic artifacts, but it was not the only one. The current transition from fossil fuels to electric power produces a different industrial landscape, and legacy manufacturers repeatedly demonstrate that one cannot simply engineer the outgoing paradigm's artifact on the new substrate and call it an equivalent; an electric vehicle is not an internal-combustion car with batteries attached but a distinct design whose architecture, software, supply chain, and operational logic are native to the new substrate.

Applied to organizational substrates: legacy institutions that try to describe the bonded primitive in firm-vocabulary ("decentralized firm", "DAO as a new kind of corporation", "network equivalent of a platform") are doing what Western automakers did for the first two decades of the electric transition. The forms that will dominate the new substrate are not yet named, and the vocabulary for naming them is still being produced. This is precisely the labor Gramsci identified: the slow, unglamorous work of producing the conceptual vocabulary in which the new configuration becomes evaluable on its own terms rather than as a degraded copy of the outgoing one.

A note on the name. The protocol bears the name FIGARO after the factotum of Seville: the character who declares himself the city's factotum in the famous *Largo al factotum* aria of Rossini's *Il Barbiere di Siviglia* (1816, libretto by Sterbini, drawn from Beaumarchais's *Le Barbier de Séville*, 1775). Figaro is the coordinator who arranges, brokers, and mediates between parties of otherwise incommensurable standing without owning what is being coordinated. He is the instrument by which commerce, marriage, and inheritance within a noble household are actually transacted; the household's formal principals cannot accomplish their ends without his mediation, and the coordination he provides is not itself legible as an institution in the classical sense. The naming is substantive, not decorative. A bonded settlement primitive whose construction produces a coordination function that is enforced but not owned—that holds collateral, executes commitments, and discharges resolution without occupying the position of counterparty or patron—is a factotum in the literal Renaissance sense: one that "does everything" while owning nothing. The protocol is the factotum of the network on which it is deployed; and the visibility argument we develop in this paper is, in part, an argument about naming: an institution whose coordination function lacks a vocabulary of its own remains structurally invisible *as* a coordination function. The protocol's name restores one. The naming itself dates to the project's first formulation [Genovese and Daliana, 2022], predating the present mechanism by four years; the metaphor's continuity across iterations is part of the project's intellectual record.

Remark 3.1 (On What "Visible" Means Here). Gramsci's analysis of hegemony emphasized the role of *intellectuals*—in his idiosyncratic sense—in producing the conceptual vocabulary through which arrangements become contestable. Making the coordination function visible is, in that register, a kind of intellectual labor. It is not technical exposition (technical readers already see it); it is the work of producing a vocabulary in which non-technical readers can see it without first becoming technical readers. The technical work — institutional-economic, mechanism, implementation — has been done in its own register; the present paper is the prerequisite for that work being absorbable in venues where it otherwise sounds like noise.

4 Adjacent Movements: Network States and Chambers Without Arbiters

The Gramscian diagnostic we have developed shares family resemblance with several contemporary movements that arrive at an overlapping conclusion from different starting points. Three are worth naming, both to position the present argument honestly and to identify where the bonded primitive supplies infrastructure the movements have otherwise struggled to specify.

Exit as political instrument. Hirschman [1970] distinguished three responses to institutional dissatisfaction: *exit* (take one's resources elsewhere), *voice* (argue within), and *loyalty* (neither). Hirschman's framework is the upstream reference for contemporary arguments that coordination infrastructure admits of *exit* as a meaningful alternative to *voice*—arguments which, absent credible exit options, collapse back into arguments about platform reform (voice within) or platform regulation (voice above). Our diagnostic is, from Hirschman's perspective, a claim about the artifactual character of the present exit constraint: the reason exit from the platform configuration is not a serious political option is that the coordination function has not been available outside it. A bonded settlement primitive restores the condition Hirschman required for exit to discipline incumbents without recourse to voice.

The network-state thesis. Srinivasan [2022] develops the Hirschmanian move for the cloud era: communities that form online, acquire social cohesion, build shared institutions, and eventually seek territorial and diplomatic presence. The thesis names an "economic engine" as a constitutive stage between community and recognition, but the movement has treated that stage as an unsolved sub-problem—commerce within a network-state community in practice continues to route through incumbent platforms and state-clearable fiat rails, which is to say, through exactly the hegemonic configuration the community claims to be exiting. The bonded primitive is the missing engine. This is not a claim that the network-state program is correct in its further aims; it is a claim that the program requires a commerce substrate that has, at the time of writing, no rival. A diagnostic paper is not the place to adjudicate the normative content of adjacent movements; it is the place to note where the present technical contribution supplies infrastructure that adjacent movements presuppose.

Chambers without arbiters. A recurring pattern in crypto-native coordination, variously called the decentralized autonomous chamber of commerce, the coordinator DAO, or under earlier branding the decentralized autonomous company [Larimer, 2014], is the attempt to federate merchant or participant coordination without incorporating a governance body empowered to adjudicate disputes. The attempts recurrently drift into governance because participants have no other tool for the coordination function: once dispute resolution is on the table, a voting apparatus is the default answer. The bonded primitive provides the tool, and the work splits cleanly across its two mechanisms. Mechanism 1 (asymmetric bonding) handles the enforcement function that the chamber would otherwise have to adjudicate; Mechanism 2 (buyer dominance with atomic resolution) handles the inter-party coordination function that the chamber would otherwise have to govern, by making the entire bonded mesh resolvable from a single signature without a vote; permissionless operator registration handles the membership function that the chamber would otherwise have to gatekeep. The chamber-without-arbiters ambition is not obviated by the primitive; it is made architecturally achievable, which it was not before — and the architectural availability traces directly to the two-mechanism composition rather than to either mechanism alone.

Climate and cross-sovereignty coordination. Climate change is a coordination problem that has resisted solution in part because its scale exceeds any single sovereignty. The voluntary carbon market, established to coordinate emissions-reduction credit across jurisdictional boundaries, has been wracked by integrity crises [West et al., 2020]: many credits bear little relationship to the emissions reductions they claim. The structural failure is that buyers cannot verify credits directly and have no choice but to trust a registry. The bonded primitive offers a different arrangement. A buyer bonded with a carbon-removal operator can require schema-validated GHG attestations (§4 of the implementation paper), verify the attestations against the primitive's schema registry, and hold the operator's bond until resolution. This is not a claim that FIGARO solves climate change; it is a claim that the infrastructural failure mode of the voluntary carbon market — trusted registries producing credits without verifiable provenance — is of the same structural type as the coordination-function failure mode of the platform economy this paper has been analyzing, and that the primitive addresses both in the same way.

Position of the present paper. The Gramscian framing is neither a substitute for nor a rival to these movements. It supplies the diagnostic register within which the coordination-infrastructure question can be posed at all; the movements supply concrete political and organizational programs within which the bonded primitive can be deployed. A reader arriving from the network-state literature should read this paper as naming the hegemonic configuration their program is trying to exit; a reader arriving from the coordinator-DAO literature should read it as naming the reason their coordinator-without-governance attempts have been structurally difficult.

5 Why This Argument Is Hard to Make

The practical difficulty of communicating the implications of infrastructure shifts of this kind is not, we argue, a communicative deficit on the part of the proponent. It is a structural feature of arguing against an arrangement whose necessity has achieved hegemonic status.

The asymmetry of argument. Proposing to remove a structure that most people do not know is there is qualitatively different from proposing a better version of the same structure. The latter operates within the existing register of debate (more efficient platforms, fairer firms, more inclusive corridors); the former requires first establishing the existence of the register itself. The proponent is not asking the listener to accept a counter-argument; they are asking the listener to accept that there is something to argue about. This is much harder.

The evaluator's predicament. A skeptical reader evaluating an architectural proposal that implies the dissolution of a major incumbent must do two unfamiliar things at once: (a) accept that the incumbent's necessity is contingent, and (b) evaluate a specific alternative. Either move is hard alone; together they are uncomfortable enough that many readers, in good faith, decline both and conclude that the proposal is implausible. The conclusion is rational under the listener's actual evaluative budget; it is not evidence about the proposal.

The proponent's inversion. A proponent of an architectural alternative typically frames the work in terms of the incumbent: "A better Uber", "Uber without the middleman", "a decentralized firm". This framing has two costs. First, it concedes the centrality of the incumbent: the alternative is defined relative to it. Second, it re-encodes the incumbent's hegemonic vocabulary into the alternative, importing the very assumptions the alternative is supposed to dissolve. We argue that this is structurally a mistake. The right framing is disjunctive: the alternative does what the incumbent does *plus* what the incumbent prevents, where the latter is the substantive contribution. "A better X" frames are near-guaranteed to be misread; the work of finding non-incumbent vocabulary is the political-economy work the technology cannot do for itself.

The role of repeated exposure. Hegemonic propositions are dissolved not by definitive argument but by sustained exposure to alternative arrangements that function. The role of working examples (process trees that resolve without a platform, treasuries that coordinate without a firm, corridors that settle without a sovereign) is not to prove that the alternative is possible; it is to gradually shift the horizon of the imaginable. This is the slow, not the dramatic, register of institutional change.

6 Conclusion

This paper has argued that the platform, the firm, and the corridor share a structural property: each is a contingent coordination architecture that has achieved hegemonic status in the Gramscian sense. The recently developed settlement primitive of the mechanism paper makes the coordination function performed by each entity visible as a separable design artifact. This visibility is the prerequisite for any subsequent substitution argument; it does not, by itself, settle whether substitution will occur, at what rate, or in which regions of the transaction space.

The political-economy stakes are real but should not be overstated. The argument is diagnostic rather than predictive: a proposition that is presupposed cannot be evaluated; making the proposition explicit is the work that political economy must do before institutional analysis can proceed. A more cautious version of the same point: in a hegemonic arrangement, the substantive work of an architectural proposal is largely the work of producing the vocabulary in which the proposal becomes evaluable. The technology rarely does this work for itself.

We close with two observations of method. First, the kernel is ideologically agnostic; the graph is the politics. The irreducible settlement primitive (§1.4 of the mechanism paper)—the `commit`-and-`resolveProcess` operations, the bond structure, and the equilibrium they induce—contains no commitments about currency, jurisdiction, identity, arbitration, role structure, price-discovery, or contribution metric. All of these are expressed in the graph that parties compose on top of it: a Dutch-auction-and-private-operator graph expresses a market-liberal pattern; a cooperative-bonding-and-contribution-weighted-resolution graph expresses a cooperative one; an interest-free risk-sharing graph expresses an Islamic-finance one. The kernel enables each and prefers none. This is not rhetorical evasion but the architectural consequence of placing the enforcement function at TCP/IP altitude: a layer below which nothing remains to factor out, and a layer above which normative choices become legible as choices rather than as properties of the infrastructure. A defender of platforms can use the visibility move of this paper to clarify what is actually being defended; a critic can use it to clarify what is actually being criticized; neither has to contest the primitive itself. Second, the hegemony framework applies recursively. If the bonded settlement primitive itself becomes hegemonic in turn—if its necessity becomes presupposed in the way that platform necessity is presupposed today—the same diagnostic work will be required to make *that* contingency visible. There is no terminal infrastructure; there is only the next infrastructure whose contingency we have not yet learned to see.

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